to cut rates—a process that assumed a feverish pace soon.[47]

If wrestling with BI was not enough, trouble also came in the form of local authorities who connived with their fellow English merchants. Since the entire district administration was exclusively European, they naturally ganged up with BI to undermine the Swadeshi effort.

D.G. Waller, an ICS officer, and the head assistant collector of Tuticorin colluded with the port doctor (Tuticorin was the port for indentured labour to Ceylon, it may be recalled, and the doctor was in charge of quarantine and other related matters), sea customs officer and port officer to work against the Swadeshi concern. Waller also warned some local policemen whom he believed to be in sympathy with the Swadeshi cause. Using the pretext of an alleged collision between the Swadeshi launch and the BI launch (on 25 June), he ordered that the Swadeshi steamer should leave the jetty only at 4.45 p.m. or at least fifteen minutes after the BI ship set sail. The swiftness and arbitrary nature of the order took the Swadeshi firm by surprise who, in the first place, denied that any collision had taken place. Waller asked the police to transfer the complaint preferred by the native merchants to his court but sat on it for over two weeks. When the port officer pleaded helplessness in countermanding the order, the Swadeshi firm appealed to the district collector,[48] who fortunately redressed their grievance.[49]A year later, the district collector, Wynch, recalled it as ‘a collision between the boats of the two companies but this one occurred and is said to have created [unnecessary] local feeling. The district magistrate himself went down and settled the matter amicably.’[50] That Waller and the BI agent Eric Campbell lived in the same bungalow also did little to inspire confidence in his impartiality.[51] Apart from the larger imperial ideology that the European officers shared, Tuticorin was a small town where less than fifty Europeans lived, and this led to a racial bonding that strengthened a shared hostility to the Swadeshi enterprise.

Waller’s ire next turned to the employees of the Swadeshi firm. First, he ordered Annakutty Sahib of Shah Line Company not to be present either at the railway station or the harbour. Next, he warned a senior policeman,